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Submission by the Synod of Victoria and Tasmania, Uniting Church in Australia to inquiry onto the 2025 Federal election

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The Synod of Victoria and Tasmania, Uniting Church in Australia welcomes the opportunity to make a submission to the inquiry into the 2025 Federal election.

The submission will address our on-going concern about declining trust in the democratic system by people on lower incomes. In our system, growing financial inequality feeds greater political inequality, which erodes the common good and social cohesion. Additionally, we briefly address the term of reference to consider the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election.

The 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer reported that trust in government in Australia declined from 50% to 47% between 2024 and 2025.[1] They found that the proportion of Australians who believe that government leaders purposely mislead people by saying things they know are false or gross exaggerations increased from 58% in 2021 to 64% in 2025.[2] Further, the proportion of Australians who believe that journalists and reporters purposely mislead people by saying things they know are false or gross exaggerations increased from 64% to 68% over the same period.

Australia currently has two political systems. The formal democracy provides that each voter gets one vote. In parallel, there is an informal system where the greater the wealth of a person the greater their ability to skew our democracy to their preferences. In our democracy, people with wealth have many ways in which they can skew democracy to their preferences. For example:

- They can make political donations to assist in the election of candidates or the party they prefer;
- They can fund think tanks and civil society organisations or even establish a think tank or civil society organisation to push their agendas into the public arena;
- They can hire lobbyists to try and influence political representatives and senior public servants;
- The wealthy gain disproportionate airing of their views in mainstream media; and,
- The super wealthy can even buy and own media outlets to push their preferred views into the community.

[1] "2025 Edelman Trust Barometer. Global Report. Trust and the Crisis of Grievance", 2025, 43.
[2] "2025 Edelman Trust Barometer. Trust and the Crisis of Grievance. Australia Report", 2025, 10.

Most concerns about the influence of political donations are whether an individual or an entity can use donations to gain access and influence over politicians. As the extensive work by Assistant Professor Julia Cagé has demonstrated, through political donations in France being concentrated towards the wealthiest people collectively, the preferences of the wealthy have collectively drowned out the interests of those on lower incomes, and contributed to the silencing of these voices in political discourse.[3] Thus, our concern should not just be about the influence of political donations considered individually, but the collective effect of political donations and how they skew democracy to the preferences of those that collectively have financial wealth at their disposal.

From the point of its formation in 1977, the Uniting Church in Australia declared its commitment to every citizen having the right to participate in decision-making in the community:

> *We affirm our eagerness to uphold basic Christian values and principles, such as the importance of every human being, the need for integrity in public life, the proclamation of truth and justice, the rights for each citizen to participate in decision-making in the community, religious liberty and personal dignity, and a concern for the welfare of the whole human race.*

The 2025 Synod meeting of hundreds of delegates from congregations across Victoria and Tasmania adopted the following resolution:

> *That the Synod resolves:*
> *(a) To express its concern that in the Australian democratic system a person's wealth allows them to have a more significant say in laws and government policies, often to the detriment of the common good and undermining trust in democracy and government by people on lower incomes;*
> *(b) To request the Australian Government to instigate reforms that will curb the influence of wealth in the democratic system, including:*
>> *(i) Restricting private political donations and the amount candidates and political parties can spend on elections so that public funding of elections is the primary way elections are funded;*
>> *(ii) Implementing a system where all Australian citizens can make a small government-funded donation to the political party or candidate of their choice before an election;*
>> *(iii) Requiring the amount of all private political donations to be disclosed on tax returns, and aggregated data on political donations by income level be deidentified and made public.*
> *(c) To request the Australian Government to regulate the influence of political lobbying by:*
>> *(i) Legislating the creation of a Lobbying Register that covers in-house professional lobbyists as well as third-party lobbyists;*
>> *(ii) Requiring all professional lobbyists to disclose to the Lobbying Register which*
>> *politicians and public servants they have met with, including when, why, on whose behalf, and the topics that were discussed;*
>> *(iii) Requiring Ministers to publish their diaries covering official duties on a regular basis; and*
>> *(iv) Prohibiting Ministers and senior public servants from being employed in direct*
>> *lobbying activities related to their previous portfolios for at least three years after leaving office.*

[3] Julia Cagé, "The Price of Democracy. How money shapes politics and what to do about it", (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2020).

(d) To request the Australian Government to build greater confidence in Australia's democratic government by requiring that the public service recognise the value of people's experience by using meaningful codesign with people directly impacted by policy as the default mechanism for designing services and programs that people need;
(e) To write to the Prime Minister, Special Minister of State, Attorney General, Leader of the Opposition, Shadow Special Minister of State, Shadow Attorney General and the Leader of the Greens to inform them of the resolution; and
(f) To inform the National Assembly and other Synods of clauses (a) to (e) above.

In somewhat of a contrast to the 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer, analysis of the 2025 election based on ANU polling and an analysis by Professor Nicholas Biddle suggests a "democracy bounce" effect that has seen an increase in optimism about the Australian political system.[4] Political institutions are seen to be more trustworthy, particularly with respect to Parliament, political parties and the federal government. The election itself was seen to have integrity. However, legitimacy derived from democratic representativeness within parliament varied considerably. Noticeably, Australians are of the belief Australian democracy is more suited to represent the interests of the wealthy than those on low incomes, especially amongst those with lower levels of formal education.

The following are Professor Biddle's findings leading to his conclusion for greater attention for media fairness and data use, greater attention to representational equity within Parliament, and institutional responsiveness to those on the margins of society:[5]

- **Life Satisfaction -** On a scale on 0 to 10, Australians were feeling less satisfied with life with a value of 6.35 at the time of the 2025 federal election compared to 6.77 at the 2022 election. For contrast, life satisfaction was 6.52 during the COVID lockdowns of 2020 and 2021.[6] Key contributors to contemporary dissatisfaction were high levels of financial stress that has remained consistent since the beginning of 2023, and middling levels of social trust.[7]
- **Trust In Democracy -** 73.3% of Australians reported being satisfied with democracy at the May 2025 election, up from 67.1% prior to the election over March and April. On average, women were significantly more dissatisfied in democracy than men. Both younger and older Australian have higher satisfaction than those in the middle age range of 35-44 years.[8] With regard to education, those with degrees were more satisfied in democracy than those without. At the same time, those who have completed a Year 12 qualification were more satisfied than those who have not.[9]
- **Confidence and Trust in Institutions -** More people were confident in the Federal Government at 43.1% since the 2023 referendum. However, confidence remained lower than during the COVID pandemic and after the May 2022 election.[10] Financial stress remained an important variable in determining confidence and trust in institutions.[11] Women, those with lower education, those born in Australia, those aged between 55 and

[4] Biddle, Nicholas 2025, 'Shifting Trust and Satisfaction: Monitoring a Key Dimension of Democratic Resilience in Australia (October 2024 to May 2025), Australian National University, School of Politics and International Relations, *Australian Resilient Democracy Research and Data Network: Discussion Paper 7*, p.23, available at: https://politicsir.cass.anu.edu.au/research/publications/shifting-trust-and-satisfaction-monitoring-key-dimension-democratic
[5] Ibid.
[6] Ibid., 3.
[7] Ibid., .4-5.
[8] Ibid., 9.
[9] Ibid.
[10] Ibid., 9.
[11] Ibid., 12.

64, and those living outside of a capital city were also more likely to experience lower levels of trust in institutions.[12]

- **2025 Election Views: Fairness at the ballot -** 77.9% of Australians thought vote counting was fair. 72.1% of Australians saw election officials as fair. Further, 69.4% of people felt that at the ballot box voters were offered genuine choice in who to vote for.[13] Alarmingly, 12.5% of Australians felt threatened with violence at the polls.[14]
- **2025 Election: Media and Technology –** Only 10.1% of Australians felt journalistic coverage of the elections was very often fair, while 31.9% indicated fair coverage happened often. Overall, trust in media (social or political) had not increased.[15] As elections become more data driven with the use of algorithms to access personal data, 18.5% of Australia's felt candidates very often misused their data to spread campaign messages, while 26.9% felt it occurred often.[16]
- **Representation -** Younger Australians, people without a year 12 qualification and those under financial stress had lower confidence in the representativeness of our democracy. There persists sentiment amongst 77% of Australians that "rich voters" were being better represented fairly well, while 50.2% believed voters on low incomes are represented fairly well.[17] Belief that that parliament is not representative of the population directly impacts its democratic legitimacy, and the extent parliamentarians are perceived as being able to reflect the needs and aspirations of the electorate.[18] 11.1% of Australians believed that following the 2025 election parliament was not able to represent people at all, while 59% believe it can fairly well.[19]

Dissatisfaction with the Australian democratic system also appears to be greater with younger people. Research conducted by Griffith University that interviewed 1,500 Gen Z Australians in 2023 found almost half only voted to avoid getting fined.[20] Gen Z Australians who did not vote were more likely to be unemployed. Non-voters from Gen Z were more likely to be members of organisations such as charities or church groups. They were more alienated from the democratic process. Only 11% of the Gen Z people surveyed stated they voted in the 2022 election because "there was a party candidate I wanted to vote for". One in five said their primary motivation for voting was because "I thought that voting makes a difference".

The role of wealth in undermining trust in the democratic system

Since the 1980s, there has been growing income and wealth inequality in Australia. Wealth correlates to political influence in our system. Thus, a growing proportion of people in the bottom 50% of income earners feel left behind and do not feel their interests and concerns are being taken seriously within the political system.

The World Inequality Database (https://wid.world/country/australia/) shows that income distribution in Australia has matched the global trend for wealthy countries. Between the First World War and 1980, the share of income for the bottom 50% of Australians increased from 15.3% to 18.7%. The income share of the top 10% decreased from 36.6% to 24.9%. After 1980, the trend reversed with the rise of neoliberal economics favouring the wealthy. By

[12] Ibid., 12.
[13] Ibid.,15.
[14] Ibid.
[15] Ibid.
[16] Ibid.
[17] Ibid., 19.
[18] Ibid.
[19] Ibid.
[20] Sofia Ammassari, Duncan McDonnell and Ferran Martinez Coma, '47% of Gen Z mainly vote to avoid a fine. It's a sign of younger Australians' discontent with democracy', *The Conversation,* 7 April 2025.

2022, the neoliberal economic policies pursued by Australian governments saw the income share of the bottom 50% of Australians drop to 16.4%, while the top 10% had their share increase to 32.9%.

The OECD has pointed out that:[21]

> *The increasing concentration of economic resources in the hands of fewer people presents a significant threat to political and economic systems. If the financing of political parties and election campaigns is not adequately regulated, money may also be a means for powerful special interests to exercise undue influence and "capture" the policy process.*

Further, they pointed out the negative consequences for the wider community:[22]

> *Over the past three decades, income inequality has risen in most OECD countries, reaching, in some cases, historical highs. The increasing concentration of economic resources in the hands of fewer people presents a significant increase in the risks of policy capture. When government policymaking is captured by a handful of powerful special interests, the rules may be bent in favour of the rich. The consequences of a widespread feeling that governments are not working in the wider public interest are grave, leading to the erosion of democratic governance, the pulling apart of social cohesion, and the undermining of crucial concepts that underlie democracy, such as equal opportunities for all….*
>
> *The relationship between inequality and undue influence in politics through political financing is often overlooked. Socioeconomic inequality is only the tip of an iceberg of inequalities of different dimensions, including differences in influence, power, and voice.*

The Australian High Court has expressed concerns in the joint judgement in *McCloy*, which acknowledged that political contributions could be inappropriately used to secure specific favours from the recipient. The High Court also acknowledged the problem of 'clientelism', which "arises from an office-holder's dependence on the financial support of a wealthy patron to a degree that is apt to compromise the expectation, fundamental to representative democracy, that public power be exercised in the public interest."

From French economist Julia Cage:

> *The essential point remains that today, those who win are those who pay. And in many countries, the system now in place encourages donations in such a way that the poor pay to satisfy the political preferences of the super-rich.*[23]
>
> *… donations to political parties and election campaigns are a class phenomenon that, by and large, benefits the most conservative parties; a much larger proportion of the super-rich make contributions, and when they do, these are much larger than those of citizens on low incomes.*[24]
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> *Such a system may potentially boost the capacity of the wealthiest social groups to win election battles and to "buy" public policies of their choosing.*[25]

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[21] OECD, 'Financing Democracy: Funding of Political Parties and Election Campaigns and the Risk of Policy Capture', OECD Public Governance Reviews, OECD Publishing, Paris, 2016, 15.
[22] Ibid., 24-25.
[23] Julia Cagé, "The Price of Democracy. How money shapes politics and what to do about it", (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2020), xii.
[24] Ibid., xix.
[25] Ibid., 2.

Cage points out that the wealthy disproportionately make private political donations, using French data as an example:[26]

> *Whereas fewer than 0.8 per cent of fiscal households contribute each year financially to a political party, they represent 2.7 per cent of the richest 10 per cent, 3.8 per cent of the richest 1 per cent, 5 per cent of the richest 0.1 per cent, and – most striking of all – more than 10 per cent of the 0.01 per cent of French people with the highest incomes.*

It is impossible to do such an analysis in Australia, as the ATO does not collect data on people making political donations in a way that would allow an analysis to be conducted of how political donations are distributed by the income distribution of the donors.

For the data that is visible in Australia, analysis of political donations in the Federal system between the 1998 – 1999 and 2020- 2021 financial years by the Centre for Public Integrity found:[27]

- the top 5 donors whose donations are disclosed contributed 31.5% of total donations;
- the top 10 donors contributed 41.4%;
- the top 20 donors contributed 52.8%; and,
- the top 20% of donors contributed 90%.

The average donation in an election year was $154,548[28], the entire salary for someone in the top 10% of employees.

In 2016, a victorious candidate for the US Senate spent, on average, more than US$10 million. In France, the average victorious parliamentary candidate spent 41,000 euros compared to an average spend of 18,000 euros. In the UK in 2015, the average spend for a victorious candidate was 10,000 euros compared to the average of 4,000 euros.[29]

Jan-Werner Müller has raised concerns about the emergence of a "donor class".[30]

Low-income people and distrust in electoral democracy

The failure of Australian democracy to make a significant proportion of people feel like their preferences are represented leads to a lack of trust in the democratic system. A 2018 study by Democracy 2025 found that those more likely to feel satisfied with the status quo of our democracy were men aged over 55 and on incomes of more than $200,000 a year. Those more likely to be unhappy with our democracy were Australian-born women aged in their forties and on incomes of less than $50,000 a year.[31]

The Australian Public Service Commission 2023 national survey of trust and satisfaction in Australian democracy found the rates of people being dissatisfied or very dissatisfied with Australian democracy were:[32]

- 13% of all respondents;

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[26] Ibid., xvi.
[27] The Centre for Public Integrity, 'A few loud voices. The concentration of Commonwealth political donations', January 2023, 3-5.
[28] Ibid. 4.
[29] Julia Cagé, "The Price of Democracy. How money shapes politics and what to do about it", (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2020), 22.
[30] Jan-Werner Müller, "Democracy Rules", (UK: Allen Lane, 2021), 150.
[31] Democracy 2025, 'Trust and Democracy in Australia. Democratic decline and renewal', Museum of Australian Democracy and University of Canberra Institute for Governance and Policy Analysis, December 2018, 10.
[32] Australian Public Service Commission, "Trust and Satisfaction in Australian Democracy. 2023 National Survey", 33.

- 25% of people experiencing social isolation;
- 24% of people who have experienced financial hardship;
- 23% of people who were self-employed;
- 23% of people unable to work;
- 21% of people who are discriminated against;
- 21% of people with disability;
- 20% or people with a mental health condition; and,
- 16% of people with an education level lower than Year 12.

As noted by the ALP's analysis of its 2019 election loss:[33]

> *Voter trust in politics globally and in Australia has collapsed, resulting in economically insecure, low-income voters treating all political promises with extreme scepticism while being highly receptive to negative campaigns.*

A caution here is that the impact of low trust and satisfaction with electoral democracy could be correlated with lower levels of formal education, which in turn is largely correlated with lower incomes. As pointed out by Professor Michael Sandal, one of the most significant prejudices and sense of superiority held by people with higher levels of formal education is against those they regard as uneducated.

In a series of surveys conducted in the United Kingdom, the Netherlands, and Belgium, a team of social psychologists found that tertiary-educated respondents have more bias against less-educated people than they do against other groups that are targets for prejudice. The researchers surveyed the attitudes of well-educated Europeans towards a range of people who are typically targets of discrimination – Muslims, people of Turkish descent living in Western Europe, people in poverty, the obese, people with disability and the less educated. They found that the poorly educated were disliked most of all.[34]

In a similar study conducted in the US, the researchers offered a revised list of groups targeted for prejudice, including African Americans, the working class, people in financial poverty, people living with obesity and less educated people. The American respondents also ranked the less formally educated at the bottom.[35]

The researchers concluded that well-educated people, as defined by formal education, are no less biased than less-educated people, "it is rather that [their] targets of prejudice are different." Moreover, the well-educated are unembarrassed by their prejudice. They may denounce racism and sexism but are unapologetic about their negative attitudes towards the less formally educated.[36]

Using data from the European Quality of Life Survey[37], Noord et al. (2023) found that lower-educated individuals reported stronger feelings of social misrecognition - a sense that they do not have an influential position in society and their value is not recognised. In turn, these feelings result in political alienation, including political distrust, electoral disengagement, and

[33] Craig Emerson and Jay Weatherill, "Review of Labor's 2019 Federal Election Campaign", 29.
[34] Michael Sandal, *The Tyranny of Merit. What's Become of the Common Good?* (UK: Penguin Books, 2021), 95.
[35] Ibid., 95
[36] Ibid., 95-96.
[37] Eurofound, Dubois, H., Jungblut, J., Pöntinen, L. (2017). European quality of life survey 2016 : quality of life, quality of public services, and quality of society: overview report, Publications Office. https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2806/964014

discontent towards democracy.[38]

The point of the deviation in relation to levels of formal education is that those with higher formal education and greater wealth are not likely to be meaningfully considerate of the interests of people on lower incomes with less formal education within the democratic system. Thus, the source of dissatisfaction with the democratic electoral system from people on low incomes is likely to also be tied up in lower levels of formal education that makes them the target of prejudice.

A 2023 Belgian study observed that politicians were biased against people with lower levels of formal education and lower incomes, perceiving their opinions as less legitimate compared to higher-educated individuals.[39] The psychological tendency of Belgian politicians to minimise the importance of perspectives of those with lower income and formal education contributes to unequal representation. In turn, the attitudes of the politicians affect the levels of political trust of people on lower incomes and lower formal education levels and their perception of the efficacy of the democratic system.

Philosopher Michael Sandal has pointed out that if people on lower incomes and lower levels of formal education are to trust in society again, they need more than charity from the wealthy and middle class. They need to be able to make a meaningful contribution to society and have a meaningful say in society. Drawing on Catholic social teaching he wrote:[40]

> *Theories of contributive justice teach us that we are most fully human when we contribute to the common good and earn the esteem of our fellow citizens for the contributions we make. According to this tradition, the fundamental human need is to be needed by those with whom we share a common life.*

The sense of the democratic system being rigged for the benefit of the wealthy undermines social cohesion. The 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer reported that 62% of Australians held a moderate (41%) to high (21%) level of grievance against business, government and the rich.[41] Of those with a high level of grievance against business, government and the rich, only 19% trusted government and only 12% saw government as a unifying force that brings people together.[42] Further, while the top 25% of income earners has trust in government, only 39% of people on the lowest 25% of incomes trusted government in Australia.[43]

The 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer also found that 72% of Australians believe the wealthy don't pay their fair share of taxes and 60% believed the selfishness of the wealthy causes many of our problems.[44]

Lack of trust in democracy helps to drive people to resort to extreme means, with the 2025 Edelman Trust Barometer finding that:[45]

- 19% of Australians believed that spreading disinformation was a viable means to drive change;

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[38] Noord, J., Spruyt, B., Kuppens, T., & Spears, R. (2023). Classified out of society? How educational classification induces political alienation through feelings of misrecognition. *The British Journal of Sociology*, 74(5), 858–872. https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-4446.13040

[39] Sevenans, J., & Walgrave, S. (2023). How Politicians Downplay Lower-Educated Citizens' Opinions. *Legislative Studies Quarterly,* 48(2), 425–439. https://doi.org/10.1111/lsq.12380

[40] Michael J. Sandel, "The Tyranny of Merit. What's become of the Common Good?" (UK: Penguin Books, 2020) 212.

[41] "2025 Edelman Trust Barometer. Global Report. Trust and the Crisis of Grievance", 2025, 18.

[42] "2025 Edelman Trust Barometer. Trust and the Crisis of Grievance. Australia Report", 2025, 20, 33.

[43] "2025 Edelman Trust Barometer. Trust and the Crisis of Grievance. Australia Report", 2025, 9.

[44] Ibid., 11.

[45] Ibid., 12.

- 16% believed that the threat or use of violence was a viable means to drive change; and,
- 18% of Australians believed that damaging property was a viable means to drive change.

The need for meaningful mechanisms of mass democratic participation

The decline of trust and satisfaction in democracy by people on lower incomes and with lower wealth requires reforms that reduce political inequality and moves the system back to where people have more of an equal say, in line with "one person, one vote". The reforms will require a blend of reducing the ability of those with wealth to skew the political system to their preferences with creating opportunities for people to have meaningful participation in our democracy on a mass scale. Allowing a few hundred people to participate in citizen juries by lottery is not going to cut it. Such juries may increase the sense of meaningful participation for the handful of people who are able to serve on the juries deliberating on an issue, but are unlikely to create a sense of meaningful participation in the political system for the vast majority.

Research by the Rew Research Centre found that people across 24 countries surveyed wanted more meaningful opportunities to participate in the democratic system, such as through mechanisms of direct democracy.[46]

The Australian Public Service Commission 2023 national survey on trust and satisfaction in Australian Democracy found that 66% of people who were dissatisfied with how democracy works believe people should get more say on government priorities.[47]

One mechanism that has allowed for mass engagement in democratic processes in a meaningful way has been the system of democracy vouchers used in the US city of Seattle. Since 2017, each voter of Seattle gets four US$25 (AU$39) publicly funded democracy vouchers that can be donated to the candidate of their choice in local council elections. The vouchers are paid for through a property tax. The system has been used in the 2017, 2019, 2021 and 2023 elections. As a result, Seattle now has the largest and most diverse donor pool in the US, with a total increase of 350% of unique donors. In the 2021 election, 48,071 Seattle residents used their democracy vouchers to fund the campaigns of 11 candidates. More candidates now run in council elections, with an 86% increase in candidates in 2019 compared to previous elections. A 2020 study found that 70% of respondents who used their democracy vouchers had not previously made a political donation in any Seattle election. Candidates have changed their behaviour to spend more time door-knocking. As one political fund-raiser in Washington State told the Synod, they chase a small number of wealthy donors as a fundraiser in other parts of Washington State. In contrast, in Seattle, they must be a "friend-raiser" to persuade voters to allocate their democracy vouchers. Candidates and their staff need to door knock and have meaningful conversations with a large number of voters.

Since the Victorian Government's Energy Bill Relief Fund has been able to give residents in Victoria $250 in a Power Saving Bonus through an online application.[48], it should be easy a government to set up a system to provide for small citizen-directed donations to the party or candidate of their choice.

The system would deliver the following benefits:

- It would allow people who otherwise could not afford to do so to participate further in

[46] Laura Silver, Moria Fagan, Christine Huang and Laura Clancy, "What Can Improve Democracy?", (Pew Research Centre, 2024), 11.
[47] Australian Public Service Commission, "Trust and Satisfaction in Australian Democracy. 2023 National Survey", 15.
[48] https://compare.energy.vic.gov.au/psb-faq

Australian democracy by providing a small donation;

- The additional funding is at the choice of voters, so it avoids being seen as the parties in government allocating additional public funding to themselves;
- It will provide an incentive for candidates to seek mass support to gain funding from voters before an election rather than chasing a small number of wealthy donors; and,
- It is more likely to be used by people who have not made a political donation before compared to alternative initiatives such as government funding matching donations from existing donors up to a limit.

Given the level of cynicism about the political system, take-up is likely to be low initially. However, once established, the use will likely grow if the system is protected from being drowned out by a few wealthy donors making large donations.

Details of the Seattle Democracy Voucher Initiative

In 2015, Seattle voters passed a citizen-led initiative called the 'Honest Seattle Elections Initiative (I-233)' to implement reforms to how candidates were funded during election campaigns (SEEC 2021).[49] One of those reforms was Seattle's Democracy Voucher Program SMC 2.04.620-690 (DVP), which was the first of its kind in any jurisdiction implemented at this scale.[50] Its inaugural use was in Seattle's 2017 election cycle and then repeated again at elections in 2019 and 2021. The Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission administers the program. It is funded by a 10-year property tax levy, which raises US$3 million annually.[51]

Under the DVP, residents receive four $25 Democracy vouchers during an election cycle that can be allocated to multiple candidates or a single candidate running for local office. Barries to participation are low as residents can assign their vouchers by returing them to the Commission by mail, directly to a candidate's campaign, or through an online portal.[52] Residents are eligible to receive democracy vouchers by being at least 18 years or older and being a Seattle resident or either being a US citizen, national or lawful permanent resident.[53]

Candidates must first qualify for DVP by filing for program participation and then be certified by the Commission.[54] To qualify, candidates must take part in three debates or equivalent public events, adhere to expenditure restrictions, and agree to prohibitions on the acceptance of funding from political parties and organisations. Candidates must also receive a specified minimum number of US$10 contributions from residents and also receive a number of supporting signatures ranging from 25-100, depending on the public office being

[49] Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2021, ' Democracy Voucher Program:2021 Biennial Report', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/2021_Biennial_Report_FINAL.pdf

[50] ibid

[51] Ramsey, Kevin, Anderson, Bryce, Tesch, Julia, and Major, Jescelle 2020 'Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, Democracy Voucher Program: 2019 Election Cycle Evaluation', Berk Consulting, 1. Available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/Final%20DVP%20Evaluation%20Report%20July23_2020.pdf

[52] Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2021, ' Democracy Voucher Program:2021 Biennial Report', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, 15 available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/2021_Biennial_Report_FINAL.pdf

[53] Ibid

[54] Seattle Municipal Code 2023, Subchapter VIII – Honest Elections Seattle, 2.04.630, available at: https://library.municode.com/wa/seattle/codes/municipal_code?nodeId=TIT2EL_CH2.04ELCACO_SUBCHAPTER_VIIIHOELSE_2.04.607THARPRMACOATTOSTPALO

sought.[55]

A Democracy Voucher Outreach fund was created with a budget of $225,000 to remove barriers to participation with the DVP by providing in-language education and translated material and facilitating resident enrolment.[56]
The two primary civic engagement aims of the program are to: [57]

1. create a funding source that enables residents in Seattle to run for office; and
2. increase the number of residents who donate in local elections.

City Council District Candidates who receive vouchers were restricted to spending at most US $93,750 in the primary election and another US$93,750 in the general election in 2023.[58] They may receive up to US $300 per donor as additional donations.[59] If their opponent or an "independent entity" spends more than US$93,750, the candidates can be released from the cap.[60] Candidates who did not participate in the Democracy Voucher Program in 2023 were permitted to accept private donations of up to US$600 per donor.[61]

DVP in 2017: Nine candidates successfully qualified for the voucher program.[62] 540,000 Democracy vouchers were sent to residents, with the SEEC receiving a return of 72,091 vouchers.[63] For the program's inaugural year, this saw an increase of 300% in the number of Seattle residents contributing to election campaigns.[64]
DVP in 2019: 53 candidates pledged to participate in the program, and 35 candidates successfully qualified for the voucher program.[65] 476,00 Democracy Vouchers were sent to Seattle residents, with 38,000 residents returning a total of 147,892 vouchers.[66]
DVP in 2021: 512,746 Democracy Vouchers were sent to Seattle residents. In total, the

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[55] Ibid and Candidate FAQs - DemocracyVoucher | seattle.gov
[56] Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2021, ' Democracy Voucher Program:2021 Biennial Report', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, 15 available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/2021_Biennial_Report_FINAL.pdf
[57]Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2021, ' Democracy Voucher Program:2021 Biennial Report', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, 5, available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/2021_Biennial_Report_FINAL.pdf
[58] Candidate FAQs - DemocracyVoucher | seattle.gov
[59] Ibid.
[60] Gregory Scruggs, "Can Small-Money Democracy Vouchers Balance Out Big-Money PACs in Seattle's Municipal Elections", Next City, 6 August 2019.
[61] Candidate FAQs - DemocracyVoucher | seattle.gov
[62] Ramsey, Kevin; Anderson, Bryce; Tesch, Julia; and Major, Jescelle 2020 'Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, Democracy Voucher Program: 2019 Election Cycle Evaluation', Berk Consulting, 1. Available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/Final%20DVP%20Evaluation%20Report%20July23_2020.pdf
[63] Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2017, ' Democracy Voucher Program: Biennial Report 2017', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, 14 available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/Agendas%20and%20Minutes/2021%20Agendas%20and%20Minutes/Nov%203%202021/2017BiennialReport.pdf
[64] Ibid, 5-7.
[65] Heerwig, Jennifer and McCabe 2020, Building a More Diverse Donor Coalition: An Analysis of the Seattle Democracy Voucher Program in the 2019 Election Cycle, Georgetown University, McCourt School of Public Policy, 2, available at: https://mccourt.georgetown.edu/news/building-a-more-diverse-donor-coalition/
[66] Ramsey, Kevin, Anderson, Bryce, Tesch, Julia, and Major, Jescelle 2020 'Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, Democracy Voucher Program: 2019 Election Cycle Evaluation', Berk Consulting, 12-13. Available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/Final%20DVP%20Evaluation%20Report%20July23_2020.pdf

SEEC received a return of 184, 474 vouchers from 48,071 residents.[67] 39,457 vouchers were returned through the SEEC online submission portal by 10,175 unique online users. [68] In 2021, 35 candidates pledged to participate in the program, and 11 candidates successfully qualified for the voucher program.[69]
DVP in 2023: As of 11 September 2023, 30 candidates had received 78,055 vouchers to a value of US$1.95 million.[70]
DVP in 2024: A special election was held to fill a City Council vacancy with four candidates competing. All candidates applied for DVP, of which three qualified for funding. $1.8 million was available to candidates, with $766,025 being distributed amongst the three qualifying candidates, representing 30,641 redeemed vouchers.[71]
DVP in 2025: A mayoral election with six candidates and a City Council election for three seats was held in November. DVP report yet to be released.

An analysis of elections since 2013 has seen a notable increase in the number of candidates running for elections. The first two years of the DVP program saw a significant increase in the candidate pool in 2017 and then remained steady, with only a marginal increase in 2019.[72] One reason for the candidate pool staying steady from 2019 could be attributed to the reduced number of incumbent candidates choosing to recontest seats. In 2015, there was a 67% reduction in incumbent candidates, 50% in 2017 and 43% in 2019.[73]

Case Studies of Seattle Democracy Voucher Candidates
"I'm a Black working-class Millennial candidate with a net worth of approximately US$10,000. If it weren't for the democracy voucher program, running for office would be a pipe dream", said Shaun Scott, who ran in the 2019 Seattle council election for the Democratic Socialists of America.[74] Shaun raised US$120,025 for his campaign from 4,801 democracy vouchers.

He narrowly lost the run-off with 47.7% of the vote. He lost to Alex Pedersen, an unaligned candidate who raised US$104,725 from democracy vouchers.

Ami Nguyen, a former public defender and the daughter of Vietnamese refugees, canvassed senior housing in 'Little Saigon' to encourage elderly residents, many of whom have never donated to a campaign or even met a candidate, to pledge their democracy vouchers to her campaign.[75]

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[67] (SEEC) Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission 2021, ' Democracy Voucher Program:2021 Biennial Report', Seattle Ethics & Elections Commission, City of Seattle, 9, available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/2021_Biennial_Report_FINAL.pdf
[68] Ibid.
[69] Ibid, 6
[70] https://www.seattle.gov/democracyvoucher/program-data/distributed-voucher-funds
[71] SEEC 2024, 'Democracy Voucher Program 2024 Report', Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, available at: https://www.seattle.gov/democracyvoucher/program-data/internal-program-reports-
[72] Ramsey, Kevin; Anderson, Bryce; Tesch, Julia; and Major, Jescelle 2020 'Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, Democracy Voucher Program: 2019 Election Cycle Evaluation', Berk Consulting, 1. Available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/Final%20DVP%20Evaluation%20Report%20July23_2020.pdf
[73] Ibid, 11-12
[74] Gregory Scruggs, "Can Small-Money Democracy Vouchers Balance Out Big-Money PACs in Seattle's Municipal Elections", Next City, 6 August 2019.
[75] Gregory Scruggs, "Can Small-Money Democracy Vouchers Balance Out Big-Money PACs in Seattle's Municipal Elections", Next City, 6 August 2019.

"The democracy voucher program has allowed me to reach out to politically marginalised communities", said Ms Nguyen. "The democracy voucher program has allowed me to connect with communities who don't have any money to spare but are the most in need of a political voice, including seniors relying on social security benefits or families who are living paycheck-to-paycheck."

Ami Nguyen was able to raise US$57,100 through democracy vouchers.

Ms Nguyen attracted 9.2% of the votes in her district.[76] The election for the district was won by Indian-American Kshama Sawant, a political organiser for Socialist Alternative who teaches economics. Ms Sawant declined to use the democracy voucher program because she feared corporate money would try to buy the election. If she had entered the DVP, her expenditure would have been capped. At the same time, her corporate-funded opponents would have had unlimited financial support.[77]

Public Sentiment

An independent survey revealed a high sense of public satisfaction in the DVP program, with 70% of respondents utilising the vouchers who had not previously donated to any Seattle political campaigns. [78] It was noted that candidates had changed their behaviour to spend more time door-knocking since the introduction of DVP than on traditional fundraising activities before their inclusion.[79] However, among the respondents, there remained concerns that private expenditure was still seen as something that could overwhelm a candidate's ability to rely on the DVP.[80] Respondents indicated support for some regulation over independent expenditure to improve the effectiveness of the DVP to increase democracy and accountability in Seattle elections.[81]

DVP Outcomes

Studies have shown a 270% increase in overall dollars from small donations under $200,[82] a total increase of unique donors of 350%[83], and a small reduction in large donations[84]. However, there appeared to be an insignificant impact on the total value of private donations, which may result from voucher qualifying rules impacting a candidate's eligibility to receive funds if they seek alternative funding. [85] Those who believe they can raise a large amount of funds from private donations were less likely to participate in DVP, as they are then not subject to restrictions on how much they can spend in the election.

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[76] https://ballotpedia.org/Ami_Nguyen

[77] Smith, Ric, "Kshama Sawant Says She Won't Use Democracy Vouchers. Why Not?", The Stranger, 24 January 2019.

[78] Ramsey, Kevin, Anderson, Bryce, Tesch, Julia, and Major, Jescelle 2020 'Seattle Ethics and Elections Commission, Democracy Voucher Program: 2019 Election Cycle Evaluation', Berk Consulting, p.20. Available at: https://www.seattle.gov/documents/Departments/EthicsElections/DemocracyVoucher/Biennial%20Reports/Final%20DVP%20Evaluation%20Report%20July23_2020.pdf

[79] Ibid

[80] Ibid

[81] Ibid

[82] Griffith, Alan and Noonen, Thomas 2022, The effects of public campaign funding: Evidence from Seattle's Democracy Voucher program, Journal of Public Economics, vol. 211, no. 104676, 2 https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0047272722000780

[83] Ibid, 14.

[84] Ibid.

[85] Ibid.

Alternatively, another analysis on elections between 2009-2021 found that for all elections (city councillors and office bearers) there was a 40% increase of total financial contributions, and a 57% increase in total expenditure.[86] While not one of the original two goals of the DVP, its implementation has given rise to an increase in voter turnout by 4.9% within Seattle's non-compulsory voting context.[87] The same study found DVP has reduced candidate reliance on large funding contributions and increased the amount received from, and reliance upon, small funding contributions. It also found small financial contributions (under $100) increased by 156%, while large financial contributions (over $250) decreased by 93% for city council candidates.[88]

In line with one of the two primary objects of the DVP, there has been an increase of 86% in the number of candidates compared to the pre-program average.[89] The analysis of the DVP program indicates a strong relationship with those who are considered low-turnout voters, other than minority voters. An increase in the overall number of voters has been attributed to the rollout of the DVP in Seattle, and resident returning a voucher has a much greater probability of voting in an election.[90] Use of vouchers has increased over subsequent years in 2017, 2019 and 2021. Analysis indicates that the DVP does have the potential to shift the composition of the pool of campaign donors to be more representative of the electorate. However, this can only be demonstrated over time, coupled with sustained institutional engagement with residents to reduce barriers that limit participation and education of candidates to encourage further engagement with the residents.[91]

Research critical of DVP participant diversity have pointed out that the same biases leading to those more likely to engage in campaign financing are proportionally the same as those most likely to participate in democratic processes prior to the voucher policy reform being implemented; namely those identified as 'white and wealthy'.[92] However, more people are participating across all social groups since the DVP. The researcher also concedes the point that as the DVP is universal in its application, which is unique in American campaign finance policy, the overall increase reflects the demography of the Seattle residents.[93] Therefore, critics have accepted that donor diversity has increased as a result of the DVP, other

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[86] Papich, Sarah 2023, 'Do Democracy Vouchers help democracy?', *Contemporary Economic Policy,* Vol. 42, No. 1, 4-24, no.1, 18, available at: https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1111/coep.12625
[87] Ibid, 22
[88] Ibid., 17
[89] Griffith, Alan and Noonen, Thomas 2022, 'The effects of public campaign funding: Evidence from Seattle's Democracy Voucher program', *Journal of Public Economics*, Vol. 211, 8, available at: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2022.104676
[90] Sridhar, Keshavan and Langeler, Chris 2021, 'Honest Elections Seattle Initiative Democracy Voucher Usage and Low-Turnout Voter Engagement Evaluation in 2017 and 2019', Win-Win Network, Seattle
[91] McCabe, Brian and Heerwig, Jennifer, 2019, 'Diversifying the Donor Pool: How Did Seattle's Democracy Voucher Program Reshape Participation in Municipal Campaign Finance?', Election Law Journal, Vol. 18. No.4, 337
[92] Yorgason, Chenoa 2025, 'Campaign Finance Vouchers Do Not Expand the Diversity of Donor Evidence from Seattle', *American Political Science Review*, vol. 119, no. 1, pp.508-516, p.521, available at: https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/american-political-science-review/article/campaign-finance-vouchers-do-not-expand-the-diversity-of-donors-evidence-from-seattle/BD8E21A4B646DE4EA56BF8787DF0FF81
[93] Ibid., 515.

barriers still persist that limit additional increases to diversity in donor participations, such as awareness of the program itself in margnalised communities.[94]

Studies have shown conclusively that lower-income residents use democracy vouchers more. Thereby demonstrating that DVP lower the financial barrier to participate in campaign financing by providing an alternative to those who are typically unable to make a campaign contribution from personal finances.[95]

The DVP impact has been limited by the ability of corporations and wealthy individuals to make unlimited independent expenditures in favour of the candidates they prefer or against candidates they dislike. In 2019, in response to a proposal to increase big business tax, the Seattle Chamber of Commerce amassed US$1 million to influence the election against the proposal. The funding included a six-figure donation from Amazon, which vigorously opposed the business tax.[96]

In response to the action by Amazon and other multinational businesses the Seattle City Council passed an ordinance in 2020 to limit political spending by what it called "foreign-influenced corporations".[97] The law bans any corporation from spending in local Seattle elections when a single foreign national owns a 1% stake in the firm or when foreign nationals in aggregate own more than 5% of the corporation.

Impact of the *Electoral Legislation Amendment (Electoral Reform) Act 2024*

The impact of the electoral reforms from the 47th Parliament appear likely to have the greatest impact on the donations and spending of independent candidates that currently rely on significant electoral spending and large donations from wealthy donors. However, the nature of the impact will remain to be seen as counter-strategies may be implemented to try and blunt the restrictions on donations and electoral spending contained within the legislation.

The greatest impact may be on the role and influence of entities like Climate 200. Donors may need to donate directly to the candidates of their choice, rather than aggregating donations through Climate 200.

Of $29.7 million donations declared to 88 independent candidates, about $10.8 million came from Climate 200.[98] It was reported that Climate 200 and Rob Keldoulis provided political donations of $961,409 to candidate Erchana Murray-Barlett.[99] Two donors were able to provide $819,470 for Kate Hook's campaign in Calare, NSW.[100]

A desired impact of the new requirements would be to force candidates to have to attract a greater number of supporters to be able to run in an election, rather than the system favouring those who can attract a small number of wealthy donors. Ideally, candidates should be people who engage with their communities and build popular support in the community, rather than being able to rely on high levels of paid advertising to build support.

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[94] Ibid., 514.
[95] Ibid., 515.
[96] Gregory Scruggs, "Can Small-Money Democracy Vouchers Balance Out Big-Money PACs in Seattle's Municipal Elections", Next City, 6 August 2019.
[97] Seattle, Wash., Ordinance 126,035 (17 Jan 2020).
[98] Andrew Gardiner, "Election spending. Big Money for indi winners and losers", *Michael West Media,* 20 October 2025.
[99] Ibid.
[100] Ibid.

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